

BRIEF 3 OF 3 — HOUSING

Local Government and the Right to Housing

Why supply alone will not solve affordability — and why national policy can quietly undermine local effort

Comparative evidence: Turin, Barcelona, Athens | Audience: city networks & municipal governments | June 2026

IN ONE SENTENCE

Cities are essential but unequally empowered actors in housing: without the legal powers to produce, acquire, or reserve stock, without a regulatory toolkit reaching beyond subsidies into rent, short-term rentals, and land use, and without national governments restraining market-distorting policies such as Golden Visa schemes, municipal ambition consistently runs up against constitutional design and market dynamics it cannot control alone.

1. The Policy Problem

Housing is the sector in which the gap between municipal ambition and constitutional capacity is most visible. Across Turin, Barcelona, and Athens, affordability pressures have intensified through financialisation and tourism-driven demand, yet the legal tools available to respond to these pressures differ sharply by jurisdiction. The comparative evidence developed in this research identifies a structural pattern: municipalities can mitigate housing precarity at the margins through targeted relief, but only those equipped with both supply-side powers and market-regulation authority can shift from palliative responses to structural intervention.

2. What the Comparative Evidence Shows

City	Toolkit available	Outcome pattern
Barcelona	Devolved Spanish/Catalan architecture enabling acquisitions, inclusionary requirements, rights of first refusal, and selective rent regulation alongside municipal supply.	Most programmatic expansion of affordable housing among the three cities, though total public housing share remains modest and faces persistent litigation.
Turin	Regionalised Italian framework recognising public housing (ERP) and municipally brokered models — public-private rehabilitation, ethical intermediation, community residences.	Targeted funds and arrears-prevention stabilise households, but stock remains scarce and turnover slow; cannot reprice the wider market.
Athens	Historical reliance on dense private stock and family-based provision rather than a social-housing sector; recent re-entry via social leasing and small-scale renovation.	Local capacity to constrain short-term rentals or capture value is mediated almost entirely by national law; municipal action reduces access barriers only at the margins.

2.1 Three cross-cutting findings

Coverage reflects the inherited housing regime and the legal tools available to alter it: without powers to produce, acquire, or reserve housing, and without durable revenue streams, coverage cannot keep pace with demand, regardless of municipal effort. Accessibility is shaped as much by market regulation as by subsidy: Barcelona's combination of demand-side support with supply-side rules (inclusionary zoning, social purchase, selective rent regulation) tempers displacement in specific sub-markets in a way that targeted funds alone, as deployed in Turin, cannot achieve, and that Athens — constrained to national-law-mediated tools — can address only marginally. Inclusion, finally, depends on whether housing policy is co-produced with civil society under stable institutional

arrangements: in Athens, solidarity networks and NGOs frequently substitute for missing state capacity, from refugee accommodation to specialised support services, while Barcelona leverages dense consortia with the region and community organisations to mainstream inclusion within a broader equity agenda.

2.2 The state as obstacle, not only as enabler

A distinctive finding of this research is that municipal housing instruments operate in the shadow of national policy choices that actively work against local effort. In all three countries studied, national inaction on structural social housing provision has left cities with chronically insufficient stock. Compounding this, the introduction of Golden Visa schemes designed to attract foreign investment, together with permissive regimes for short-term rentals, have fuelled speculative pressures that aggravate affordability crises in precisely the urban centres municipalities are trying to stabilise. Effective constitutional design therefore requires not only clarifying municipal competences but also ensuring that higher tiers of government do not undermine local capacity through contradictory, market-distorting policy.

2.3 Anti-eviction work has a distinct political character

The evidence also highlights that civil society organisations engaged in anti-eviction work occupy a position that differs from their counterparts in education or health: they function not merely as municipal collaborators but, at times, as public challengers of the very authorities with which they also seek cooperation. Anti-eviction mobilisation inherently carries a dimension of denunciation that is more unsettling for local administrations than the provision of complementary services, and city strategies should anticipate and accommodate this dual relationship rather than treating it as a coordination failure.

3. Recommendations for City Networks and Policymakers

1. Pursue a twin-track approach: expand supply while regulating the market

- a) Supply-side measures — acquisition, rehabilitation, inclusionary requirements, strengthened public and non-profit stock — should be paired with regulatory tools (rent stabilisation where lawful, short-term rental governance, habitability enforcement, robust eviction-prevention). Supply alone, as Turin's experience shows, stabilises households but cannot reprice the wider market.

2. Press for legal authority to constrain market distortion at the national level

- b) Municipal advocacy through city networks should explicitly target Golden Visa schemes and permissive short-term rental regimes as housing-policy issues, not merely investment or tourism policy. Athens' experience demonstrates that local-only action cannot offset these national-level distortions.

3. Secure a regulatory toolkit, not only subsidies

- c) Constitutional and statutory reform should grant municipalities land-use authority, leasing oversight, short-term-rental controls, and value-capture mechanisms alongside any subsidy programme. Barcelona's experience indicates this combination, not subsidy size alone, drives outcomes.

4. Formalise civil-society co-production with explicit recognition of its adversarial dimension

- d) Partnership frameworks with anti-eviction and housing-rights organisations should be designed with the expectation of constructive friction, including transparent channels for grievance and advocacy, rather than modelled on the more straightforwardly collaborative partnerships typical of education or health service delivery.

5. Use inter-city alliances for binding benchmarks, not declarations

- e) Networks such as the Mayors for Housing Alliance add most value when tied to concrete EU funding conditions or shared regulatory standards — for instance common definitions of habitability or short-term rental thresholds — rather than relying on soft, non-binding commitments.

4. Closing Note

Housing crystallises the central argument of this research with unusual clarity: constitutional design sets the outer limits of what municipal innovation, however creative, can achieve. The persistence of housing crises despite ambitious local action in cities such as Barcelona underscores that constitutional competence does not, by itself, guarantee results — it is the combination of supply-side powers, market-regulation authority, and restraint by higher levels of government from undermining local capacity that determines whether the right to housing becomes enforceable in practice.